If you're doubting yourself, watch this

Channel: Greg Lav · Published: Nov 01, 2026 · Watch: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TSJ1EBkCxbY Source: full transcript

📋 Executive Summary

Greg Lav and guests share unfiltered advice on starting a CPG brand from scratch, the mental barriers holding entrepreneurs back, why health is a business asset, and how Bloom Nutrition's setbacks became its biggest breakthroughs.

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💡 Starting a CPG Brand: Real Costs and Mental Barriers 0:46

- Greg is approached daily by people citing mental barriers to starting — the example given: someone believing they need $75,000 and asking for investor introductions
  - Greg's rebuttal: that person was standing in a city full of investors; if they can't find them there, Greg can't help

- Greg's actual startup cost guidance for a powder supplement CPG:
  - **Protein pancake mix, hydration powder, or capsules: $15,000**
  - General range to start a CPG powder brand: **$20,000–$30,000**
  - Marketing budget on top: an additional $5,000–$10,000 added gradually
- Core message: start small, the unit economics won't look great early because you haven't scaled yet, but it's absolutely possible
- The real barrier is psychological, not financial

💰 Payment Terms, Net 60, and Startup Capital 1:53

- Manufacturers often offer net payment terms, giving extra runway:
  - Net 30, Net 60, Net 90 — meaning you have that many days to pay the invoice after receiving product
  - Some founders negotiate **Net 120** on their initial purchase order
- These terms must be negotiated at the time of the first PO — they are critical to cash flow
- Greg's benchmark: if you can get $30,000–$50,000 together, you have enough flexibility to start
  - At that capital level you have "room to maneuver"
- Greg's personal context: he has launched hundreds of new products and multiple businesses and knows the real costs intimately

🚫 Why Seeking Investors Too Early Signals Weakness 3:49

- If you're in CPG and seeking investment before you have a product, Greg believes you don't fully believe in it yourself
- Investors will likely exploit that weakness:
  - A typical investor will try to acquire a large equity stake for minimal money
  - If the company underperforms, the investor ("some bad guy with a calculator") ends up owning half and giving orders
- **"Freedom without money is just paper. If someone is always giving you orders, that money is just paper."**
- The whole point of entrepreneurship is freedom — equity dilution from desperation financing destroys that

🛌 Matt's Origin Story: From the Floor to $1M/Year 6:03

- Matt left the army in February 2023 as an E-5 earning $5,000/month; had $5,000 in savings in January
- Income trajectory:

Year	Income
2023	$33,000
2024	$333,000 (10× increase)

Year	Income
2025	$1,000,000

- He started with $3,000 and invested only his **time**
  - Began posting Stories offering online coaching for $100/month
  - First client paid $100 → Matt bought a used mattress someone was discarding from a third-floor apartment
    - Carried it down with a non-English-speaking neighbor, took it to a car wash, hosed it off, let it dry, brought it to his bedroom
  - Each subsequent $100 client funded one piece of furniture: sofa, TV, bed frame
- His fiancée (they're marrying the following year) visited before he had a proper bed — he was intensely embarrassed watching her reaction to the mattress on the floor
  - She later sold her Jeep for ~$9,000 to move from Philadelphia; Greg bought her a Porsche after they went six months sharing one car
- Key lesson: Greg points out that anyone watching with zero income is already starting from a better position than Matt was
- **Timeline projection Greg gives: 24 months to strong six figures, 36 months to seven figures** — achievable only since roughly 2023

🏋️ Health, Sobriety, and Competitive Edge 4:34

- In 2026, Greg argues your **personality, charisma, and creativity are your most valuable business assets**
- Substances and alcohol impair those assets:
  - Greg used to smoke weed every night, rationalizing it as "relaxing to perform better tomorrow"
  - The next-day grogginess accumulates slowly but definitely impairs performance
- Concrete scenario at the expo (Vegas): people who went out the night before showed up hungover, puffy-faced, and slower
  - "If that big opportunity shows up at the expo and you're operating at 6 out of 10 of your capability — what happens?"
  - Greg himself told people at the expo, "Did you not think to shave for this event?"
- Greg's rule: he will not do business with someone visibly impaired — and says this as someone who was once in that position himself
- Chris Williamson (top-5 podcast in the country) is cited as an example: he eats and trains to **perform at his best each day**; a fit body is a side-effect, not the goal
- Greg's morning: 45 minutes of intense training every morning — it puts him in the mindset that "I can handle hard things"
- A fit body gives a young person with no social status or track record **immediate credibility** when walking into any room

- Quote from Greg: *"Once you know what 10 out of 10 feels like, no cheeseburger in the world is tempting when you know what you're capable of at 10 out of 10."*

👥 Hiring Strategy: Starting with B-Players and Scaling to A-Players 10:25

- Early on, without followers or credibility, top talent won't choose you — they'll take jobs they're more suited for
- The progression:
  - Phase 1: hire mid-tier people, still micromanage everything yourself, but buy back some time
  - Phase 2: business grows large enough to attract elite specialists
  - Phase 3: you become the least skilled person on your own team in specific domains
    - Greg's EA is better at EA work than he is
    - His marketing head understands marketing better than he does
    - His media head is better at media than he is
- Greg hired his best high-school friend Leo when he needed people he could **trust** (bank account access + house keys), not just skill
  - Early team-member issues had made him wary of strangers
- End state: specialists handle travel, brand deals, YouTube — each world-class in their lane

📈 Marketing Spend as a Percentage of Revenue 13:07

- The evergreen question: what % of revenue should go to marketing?

Stage	Marketing % of Revenue
Years 1–3 (aggressive growth ambition)	100–200% of profit
Growth mode	20–50%
Early brand years	20–40%
Healthy established business	20–40%
Great established business	50–60%

- General principle: **every profit dollar in the early years should go back into marketing**
- The margin your business can bear is the ceiling — essentially reinvest everything initially

🏢 Competing Against Entrenched Brands: The Cumulative Ad Spend Problem 14:12

- Example used: YETI Coolers — a ~20-year-old brand spending ~$10M/year on marketing for a $200M business = 5% of revenue
- A new entrant sees 5% and thinks that's the benchmark — **this is wrong**

    - YETI has accumulated 10+ years of marketing investment; that's $50M+ in cumulative impressions you're competing against on day one
    - CPM (cost per thousand impressions) has roughly **quadrupled** since 2019 — so $5M in 2019 ≈ $20M today
- Bloom's case in energy drinks: competing with brands that spent $10M/year for 20 years = ~$500M in impression value stored in consumer memory
- The arbitrage solution Bloom used:
    - In 2023, they achieved Coca-Cola-level awareness because they found windows where impressions were **100× cheaper** (early TikTok, emerging influencer channels)
    - You must stay in the game for 10 years AND exploit one or two major arbitrage moments, or it takes 20 years to build a billion-dollar brand

📱 TikTok Shop's AI Checkout and the New Brand Opportunity 21:36

- TikTok has launched **AI Express Checkout** and an **AI Shopping Assistant**
    - Users get product recommendations based on videos watched and searches made
    - Friction from product discovery to purchase has been essentially eliminated
- Implication for brands: the conversion problem is now solved by technology
    - **Your only job is generating awareness/demand** — the platform handles the rest
- New arbitrage question: how do you optimize your content for keywords so the AI Shopping Assistant surfaces your products first?
- Why TikTok Shop is powerful: the world's largest social platform is **actively promoting its own shopping tool** — brands that move early benefit from platform-level tailwinds
    - TikTok Shop already represents a significant and growing portion of Bloom's revenue
    - Bloom runs TikTok Shop at break-even; 30–40% of that revenue flows directly to Amazon, Target, and other retailers as consumers cross-channel
- In the AI era, **the product, brand, and authenticity matter more, not less** — the distribution pipes get commoditized but brand equity is harder to replicate
    - Ad targeting in 2026: Meta can target "a woman in Kansas with three children" vs. 2024's "a woman who wants to lose weight" — hyper-specificity means you can speak to a niche and still reach scale

🤝 Influencer Marketing Systems: Google Sheets to CRM 18:28

- Managing 1,000–3,000 creator relationships does NOT require complex software at the start
- Minimum viable system:
    - A Google Sheet (can be AI-prompted if you don't know how to build it)
    - An automated email CRM: **$1,000–$2,000/year**
    - A data pipeline automating Sheet → CRM
    - People (or yourself) finding target influencers across platforms and building a funnel

- The funnel has a **conversion rate** — that rate is determined by:
  - How authentic your brand is
  - Quality of your outreach
  - The brand value/credibility of whoever is sending the DM
- Example: if you were Andrew Huberman launching a brand and DMed 10,000 influencers from your account, you'd build a powerful funnel immediately
- Bloom's early strategy: did exactly this with Mari's account, though eventually stopped using her DMs for outreach to protect her mental peace
- What's complex is NOT the system — it's the conversion rate inputs: brand authenticity, product quality, cultural fit
- AI has dramatically reduced the complexity of building these systems — prompting can now replace engineering for basic automation
- Bloom's influencer marketing = **85% of their marketing engine**, all structured around a consistent CPM target
  - TikTok Shop affiliate creators = ~25% of influencer marketing spend; no upfront fee, commission-based
  - Some regular housewife affiliates have earned **$50,000 in a single day** selling Bloom's Clear Protein

🏭 Bloom's First Manufacturer Disaster and the Formula Ownership Trap 16:08

- When Bloom launched, almost no manufacturers would take their calls — Greg says others literally laughed and hung up
- The one manufacturer who did work with them **trapped them contractually**:
  - Greg was 22, had no lawyer, no Claude, no ChatGPT — he signed whatever seemed reasonable
  - When Bloom's pre-workout, protein, and greens powder scaled and they needed a bigger manufacturer, the original one said: **"We own the formula. You cannot use another manufacturer."**
- Bloom's response: called the bluff, walked away, found a new (better) manufacturer
  - Spent **4 consecutive days** at a table with test tubes reformulating the greens powder — tasting, adjusting, improving flavor and efficacy
  - The forced reformulation resulted in a **better product** than the original
- Two lessons Greg extracts:
  - What you start with is not what you end with
  - Mistakes only become catastrophic if they kill the business; otherwise they're education and likely an upgrade
- Additional retail setbacks: Greg has been **kicked out of retailers** for missing velocity targets; today Bloom is in **60,000 stores** — losing one account is irrelevant

🔟 The 10-out-of-10 Philosophy: Why Giving 7 Guarantees Failure 24:41

- "If you give 7 out of 10 to your big goal, you will fail — because you are competing against people like us who give 10 out of 10. Even giving 9 means you lose to someone giving 10."
- If you can't give 10 out of 10, Greg says giving **zero is better than 7** (don't dilute your effort)
- The math of Greg's 20s applied to three priorities — career, family, health:
  - Giving 6/10 to all three across your 20s = reaching your 30s with mediocrity in all three areas, then carrying that into your 40s, 50s, 60s
  - Giving 10/10 in your 20s = by your 30s you have a compounding foundation and can redirect energy
- Greg's Bloom example: he had zero IQ advantage, zero network, zero money — the only lever was **effort intensity**
  - "If I gave 7/10 to Bloom, I would have failed. So either the business failed, or I gave 10/10."
- Result of giving 10/10: now in his 30s, reputation, network, Bloom's equity, and personal brand are all compounding without proportional new effort
- The alternative: a "6 out of 10 life" across all dimensions for 70 years, retiring with a pension and a gold watch — "that's not a life I wanted"
- Prescription: **give everything for 5–10 years**, whether you start at 20, 30, or 50

🚀 Personal Brand Building: Reposting Winners and Maintaining Momentum 28:14

- Greg hit **100,000 YouTube subscribers** within a few months of starting
- Key tactic for accelerating growth once momentum exists:
  - After a few months, new followers haven't seen your older content
  - **Repost best-performing old content** alongside new content — effectively doubles your daily output
  - "In the last 2 months I gained 100K followers. None of them saw that video about selling vs. brand building."
- During the recording, Greg and his creative director JJ discover they've crossed **251,000 Instagram followers** — Greg is visibly shocked at the pace
- Warning about losing momentum:
  - Peers who started their personal brands at the same time as Greg quit when they realized it was hard work
  - Their solution: "I'll just hire a team to do it for me" — Greg calls this **lazy entrepreneurship**
  - You cannot delegate your own authenticity and presence; the personal brand only works if YOU show up
- Greg wakes up at **4:30 AM** — says you cannot afford to become lazy once you find early success
- "Objects in motion stay in motion — but YOU have to stay in motion."

💪 Daily Training, Mental Health, and the Hard-Work Happiness Link 11:35

- Greg's observation: every happy person he knows has a direct correlation with doing hard things regularly
- Every time he or close friends experienced mental health decline, they had stopped doing hard things

- His viral taxi video from London: "My mental health remedy is controlling what I can control."
- Society is becoming more comfortable → paradoxically more depressed; statistics confirm this
- Greg's solution: **do something hard every day** — the discomfort-to-happiness relationship is counterintuitive but real
- Matt's training stats shared: **145 miles run in the last 10 days**
  - He treats running as a daily warm-up and thinking time, not performance training
  - "All my ideas come while running"
  - Trains alone — group workouts cost him his 1 hour of uninterrupted thinking
- Greg trains 7 days a week, saying it's **easier than 5 days** because every day is autopilot — no decision fatigue about whether today is a rest day
- As life complexity grows (business, aging parents, children), that early solo hour becomes critical for mental clarity
- Core claim: **the real cure for male depression is being fit and pursuing something hard**

🏥 Concierge Medicine and Optimizing Biomarkers as a Business Tool 42:59

- Greg has multiple concierge doctors, each for different specialties
- Advice: get a concierge doctor as soon as you can possibly afford it — it may be your best investment
- Why: most people don't know what their body feels like fully optimized
  - Analogy: 8 hours of sleep vs. 5 hours of sleep — you'd pick 8
  - Now add perfectly optimized hormones and biomarkers on top of 8 hours: *"It feels like taking Adderall"*
- Greg's self-awareness: at Vegas expo, he knew he was at 8.5/10 (busy day prior) — acceptable for the event, but normally aims for as close to 10/10 as possible
- Sustained optimization requires a **year or more** of consistently clean blood panels — one healthy month doesn't move the needle
- Greg travels with food prepared in Tupperware (cut chicken thighs and fruit) even on private jets — no champagne, no indulgence that costs him performance
- "Once you know what 10 out of 10 feels like, no cheeseburger is worth it."
- A personal health scare around fertility was cited as the moment everything else felt irrelevant — health is the only foundation

🛒 Costco Rejection That Created Bloom Energy Drink 46:47

- Timeline: late 2022 / early 2023 — Bloom was the **#1 greens powder** on Target, Walmart, and Amazon
  - They had reached **$100M ARR** and scaled to **$180M in one year**
  - They pitched Costco
- Costco's quality-assurance process was extremely slow:
  - Greens powder has many ingredients (greens, probiotics, digestive enzymes, ashwagandha, adaptogens)

    - Each ingredient had to be verified **sequentially** — Costco couldn't work on multiple at once
    - Someone also went on maternity leave, slowing it further
    - Total time from pitch to launch approval: **over one year**
- By the time they launched at Costco, **greens powder's cultural moment had passed**
    - The category trend had faded; Bloom had banked its revenue projections on the Costco account (~$60M new account)
    - They had hired staff in anticipation — a major budget crisis followed
    - This represented 20–30% of their projected revenue shortfall for the period
- The pivot forced by the crisis: **Bloom Energy Drink** was born
    - "The rocket was starting to land, so we rebuilt it."
    - What felt like the worst year of their careers became the catalyst for their next — and bigger — product
- Lesson: *"Whatever you're struggling with right now — that is just a chapter. It will make sense. You can turn that adversity into opportunity. I promise you."*

🏬 Retail Strategy: Exclusive Launches, Shelf Placement, and Two-Way Doors 52:19

- Bloom first ordered **2,500 units** in 2018/2019 — the manufacturer's minimum order quantity
    - The factory being toured holds **900,000 cans** — 2,500 was 0.001% of that, selling out in less time than half a day
- Framework: two types of decisions:
    - **One-way door**: selling 25% equity to private equity — almost impossible to undo; you're stuck with those partners
    - **Two-way door**: launching at Walmart, not working out, pulling back and returning to e-commerce — fully reversible
- Retail launch advice:
    - Approach **3 retailers** (e.g., Sprouts, Whole Foods, Target) and offer an **exclusive 6–12 month window**
    - Negotiate: "If I give you exclusivity, what do you give me?" — better shelf placement, promotional support, partnership-level commitment
    - Worst outcome: being stocked but on the bottom shelf at the far end of the store — that's worse than not being there
    - Leverage exclusivity to get **eye-level, front-of-aisle placement**
    - Once a retailer has an exclusive, they become your partner and will likely carry future products
- What NOT to do: go store-to-store handing out samples — "We're not in 1996"
    - Instead: use TikTok and Instagram to drive your existing digital audience **into the retail store**
    - Say "We're now live at Target" and send followers there — that's the modern version of sampling

- Old beverage industry playbook is obsolete: traditional operators teaching 30-year-old tactics are why new brands are taking market share from legacy players who aren't on TikTok

🌍 Staying Relevant as a Brand Scales 45:37

- Risk of scaling: speaking to everyone means speaking to no one
  - Best CPG brands that over-expanded started talking to everyone → no one identified with the brand → new niche brand took their segment
  - Example: white-can energy drink category dynamics
- Algorithm-powered solution: in 2026, you can speak to hyper-specific audiences at scale
  - 2024 Meta ad: "Are you a woman who wants to lose weight?"
  - 2026 Meta ad: **"Are you a woman in Kansas with three children?"** — Meta finds them
  - You're simultaneously speaking to one person AND reaching millions of those specific people
- Brand credibility transfer via influencer marketing:
  - Bloom borrowed influencer audiences' trust early on — ethical credibility transfer, not theft
  - Evolved to cultural credibility: "It's sold at Target → I trust Target → I trust Bloom"
  - **FOMO** (Fear of Missing Out) is itself a credibility signal: "It sold out and I missed it → it must be worth having"
- Building a brand is fundamentally about **psychological persuasion levers** — FOMO, authority transfer, scarcity, cultural relevance
- The Japanese culture example: Americans find Japanese aesthetics aspirational (deliberate, clean, purposeful vs. American passive convenience culture) — use external cultural credibility when your brand has none yet; influencer marketing does this at scale

❤️ Work-Life Integration: Why the Boundary Between Life and Business Is a Myth 56:51

- Bloom's first "headquarters" for years was a **one-bedroom, one-bathroom Airbnb in Santa Monica**
  - Seven employees came in daily and shared Greg and his wife's personal bathroom
  - They held **Thanksgiving** there multiple times — it was just life
- Greg rejects the concept of work-life "balance" — everything is life:
  - "I think the idea of starting and stopping work is wrong."
  - Matt's Ice Coffee Hour studio was in his home; his partner was there; no line between work and personal — "everything was one."
- Now, Greg travels with his ~1-year-old son on work trips:
  - Previously: work trip → come home → be a dad
  - Now: son comes to LA, watches Greg on stage or watches the podcast recording with his mom — **that IS family time**

- Leadership under pressure: when bad news hits (a team of 100 people is watching you), you cannot show panic
  - You say "I'm handling it" — and your reputation needs to back up that statement so the team trusts it and returns to work
  - "It's like being the head of a household. You say 'I'm handling it' and they know it'll be resolved."
- The 9-to-5 employee mindset ("Finally, it's the weekend!") is why Celsius and similar established players will lose to founders who live the mission 24/7
  - "They don't see it the way I do — where your whole life is an integrated part of it."
- Greg's final framing: the most expensive thing you can do is **not pursue your goals**
  - Every day you wait, it gets harder
  - The worst case of trying and failing: you return to the life you already had — which you were going to do anyway